

IN MEMORIAM Police officers on Police Commemoration Day in Ahmedabad, Oct. 21

GUJARAT

THE MISSING COPS

"The shortage of police forces on the ground is more pronounced than the numbers suggest, as the sanctioned strength is based on 14-year-old population data," says Congress spokesperson Manish Doshi. Quoting data compiled by the Bureau of Police Research & Development in 2022, he highlights that the ratio of police personnel to the state's population is 127.82 per 100,000 people, against a sanctioned strength of 174.39.

In addition to routine policing, the Gujarat Police, for the past five years, has been tasked with gathering intelligence about drug trafficking and peddling, a responsibility previously handled almost exclusively by the Narcotics Control Bureau. Last month, the Delhi Police, in a joint operation with the local cops, carried out a bust in Ankleshwar, recovering 518 kg of cocaine worth Rs 5,000 crore from a defunct pharmaceutical factory. The narcotics had purportedly entered through Gujarat's coasts a few months earlier from South American countries and were stored in Ankleshwar for 'purification' before distribution across the country. The raid, led by the Delhi Police, left their Gujarat counterparts red-faced, once again sparking debates about staff shortages.

THE STATE POLICE NOW OUTSOURCES ROUTINE TECH JOBS LIKE MOBILE PHONE TRACKING, BUT THERE'S NO SUBSTITUTE FOR BOOTS ON THE GROUND IN, SAY, DRUG CONTROL

"Technology has come to the aid of cops for routine crime cases as tracking location, data on mobile devices and social media activity help investigations," says a retired officer working on police reforms. "Many of these tasks are outsourced to trusted ethical hackers engaged by the department. Going ahead, more specific tasks could be outsourced. However, there is no alternative to human intelligence that remains central to all forms of policing."

Sources in the police establishment say they are actively recruiting 8-9 IPS officers for the past two years, above the national average of 6-7, and will continue it for a few years. They claim to have inherited the crunch from the Congress government in the mid-1990s when Chimanbhai Patel, the chief minister then, refrained from recruiting IPS officers for three years due to a disagreement with the Union government over the Narmada Dam issue. Each year, the Union Public Service Commission recruits 150 IPS officers, who are then allocated to states based on their requirements. ■

UNDER STRAIN

- **Of the sanctioned 208 posts for IPS officers, 184 are currently filled**
- **23 of them are out on deputation, and one is under suspension**
- **At least 20 positions are being held as additional charge by senior officers**
- **The deficit is showing: Gujarat is suffering a visible dip in crime management**